

Scarlette Shockwave

Her rape and murder leads to a cause celebre and embarrasses the state Government no end

After a month of shoddy investigation, retraction of autopsy reports and investigations, the Goa Government has finally recommended a CBI probe into the rape and murder of British national Scarlett Keeling. The 15-year-old's death has put the spotlight on the dark side of Goa's drug racket and the alleged politician-drug peddler-police nexus. On February 18, Keeling was found dead on a beach and the police had initially claimed it was a case of drowning.

A demand for a second autopsy by her mother Fiona MacKeown revealed that the teen had been drugged, raped and left on the beach



AFP Photo. PHOTO COURTESY OF SCARLETT KEELING'S FAMILY

to die. Putting up a persistent fight, MacKeown blamed Goa Home Minister Ravi Naik and Director-General of Police B.S. Brar of shielding and helping the culprits. "The first report



COVER UP: Samson D'Souza, the main accused, has been taken into custody but questions remain

ignored all signs of injuries and violence while the second autopsy clearly showed sand traces in her lungs, which proved drowning in shallow water. The Government suppressed the matter initially because it would have revealed the police and politicians' links with the drug mafia," says Manohar Parrikar, Leader of the Opposition in the state Assembly.

The Government, meanwhile, has suspended the head of Goa Medical College Forensic department Dr Silvano Sapeco who had conducted the first autopsy. Left red-faced by the allegations, the police, too have sprung into action by patrolling beaches and promising to crack down on the drug trade. MacKeown now plans to take the case to the Bombay High Court.

Sociologist Ganesh Somayaji believes that Goa's policy of allowing tourist activities at night is sending out a wrong image to the world. "Tourists feel that it's a place of merry-making without restraint. But in reality, Goa is an orthodox and closed society."

Make that was. The buzzing tourism industry has clearly had its impact on the social fabric of the state. Occupations are changing and the youth, especially along the coastal villages, are moving towards tourism-related jobs. Villagers have converted homes into guest houses; saltpan workers prefer to run more lucrative tourist cab agencies and young boys make a quick buck as bartenders or run shacks instead of spending hours over textbooks. Non-government organisations say that in Anjuna, over 85 per cent students drop out after high school. "The government isn't taking cognisance of the fact that lifestyles are changing and villages are getting affected," says architect and activist Dean D'Cruz. Goa now means free-flowing beer and dancing on the beach and throbbing nightclubs tucked away in lesser-known beaches. "You can chill on the beach till 4 a.m. and then grab a bite at the beachside shacks. You can be yourself and



"IF THE POLICE NOW FIND PEOPLE ROAMING AT MIDNIGHT, THEY WILL QUESTION THEM."

KISHAN KUMAR,
INSPECTOR GENERAL OF POLICE

not worry about who is watching you," says Tina, 21, a design student from Delhi, who comes to Goa every year.

That has also opened the doors for a variety of illegal opportunities. Goan society got a rude shock when in 1991, the Margao police arrested Freddy Peats, exposing a decade-long

paedophilia racket. Peats and his German accomplice were accused of exploiting destitute children sexually and selling them to visiting paedophiles from abroad. Studies done by non-governmental organisations state that at least 100 paedophiles are active in Goa. Poverty and corrupt law enforcing bodies encourage the menace.

Drugs are the other major issue. It's no secret that Goa's secluded beaches are a haven of drugs, rave and sex and a major market for foreign narcotics dealers. The underbelly of Goa tourism since the '70s, the drug trade flourishes along the coast, particularly at Anjuna, Arpora and Vagator.